

women's 48kg class]; but we exceeded them.

"We wanted to position ourselves as one of the top teams, which we did by finishing on top of the medal tally. We knew we needed to get boxers into the final and convert those finals into gold medals. We had six boxers in the final and we won four of those bouts," says Nieva. While India had also won four gold medals at the 2022 edition, just one medal came in an Olympic weight division — Lovlina Borgohain in the women's 75kg category. This year, three of the four golds were in Olympic weight classes, where competition is the highest. More than the gold medals, it is the nature of the results that enthuses Nieva, who had previously been high-performance director with Indian boxing and later worked with the Australian national squad before joining the women's team at the start of the year.

Winning where it counts

"I think when you look at results from earlier years, you'd notice that a lot of the gold medals came in non-Olympic categories, in which the top boxers often don't take part. To win gold in Olympic weight classes is a very positive sign for us. We faced some of the top-level boxers from Asia, many of whom have won world titles. Not only did we beat them, we beat them convincingly. It shows we are on the right track," says Nieva.

With boxers from Asia winning 14 of the 24 medals in the women's divisions at the 2024 Olympics and 21 of the 40 medals at last year's world championships, Nieva believes the result from the Asian Championships is a statement of Indian women boxers' potential beyond the continental level.

"For the last 10 years or so, Asia has emerged as the strongest continent in women's boxing. Earlier it was mostly China, North Korea, Taiwan and Thailand that were very strong, but in the last couple of years, Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan have produced some world-class talent. So if you are winning in Asia, it's not too different from winning at the world level," he says.

While the medals are welcome, Nieva says it is important not to forget the work that made the result possible. "When I came to the national camp at the start of the year, I felt I already had a lot to build from. But I feel that our training discipline — the way we push ourselves in each session — has improved significantly," he says.

Over the past few months, Nieva says the team has been focusing on building what he considers high-performance athletes. "When we train, we have a purpose in mind. What our team believes in is the most important attribute of modern boxing — high-level aerobic endurance. We want that physical quality in our boxers because enduring hard training sessions is very tough on the body and can lead to injuries. Our goal is to create high-performance athletes who are also experts at boxing, rather than boxers with a poor physical base," he says.

Mission control: "Our goal is to create high-performance athletes who are also experts at boxing, rather than boxers with a poor physical base," says Santiago Nieva, the coach of the Indian women's boxing team. AFP

